Does your company suffer from **ORGANIZATIONAL SILENCE?**

Consider the implications of your employees not speaking up.

There are powerful forces in many organizations that cause widespread withholding of information about potential problems or issues by employees known as organizational silence. Organizational silence is a pervasive phenomenon in which employees withhold their opinions, concerns or feedback about organizational issues. This silence can have profound implications for organizational performance, innovation and employee morale.

Organizational silence refers to the collective phenomenon where employees choose not to share their concerns, ideas or feedback with their employers or colleagues. This silence can stem from various sources, including, but not limited to, fear of retaliation, perceived futility of speaking up, poor communication or a culture that discourages dissent. Understanding and addressing organizational silence is crucial for fostering a healthy, innovative and responsive organizational environment.

One important factor that can facilitate the creation of a climate of silence in organizations is top managers' fear of receiving negative feedback, especially from subordinates. There is strong evidence that people often feel threatened by negative feedback, whether this information is about them personally or about a course of action with which they identify.

BELIEFS

Another important factor that lies at the root of organizational silence is a set of beliefs that managers often implicitly hold about employees and about the nature of management. One such belief is that employees are self-interested and untrustworthy. Here are some of the most important reasons for organizational silence:

1. **COWORKERS:** It can cause organizational silence through reward, such as recognition and friendship, or through punishment, such as isolating a person. It is also possible through work groups to set standards and rules for behavior regarding the various situations of the organization.
2. **ORGANIZATIONAL BELIEFS:** Organizational beliefs are considered a major cause of organizational silence. The implicit belief about employees that they are self-interested and cannot be relied upon, which stems from McGregor's Theory What concerns the organization is one of the reasons for silence, and one of the organizational beliefs is that agreement and unanimity are evidence of organizational health.
3. **CHARACTERISTICS OF THE ORGANIZATION:** Characteristics of the organization as depicted in the structures and culture of the organization is one of the reasons for organizational silence.

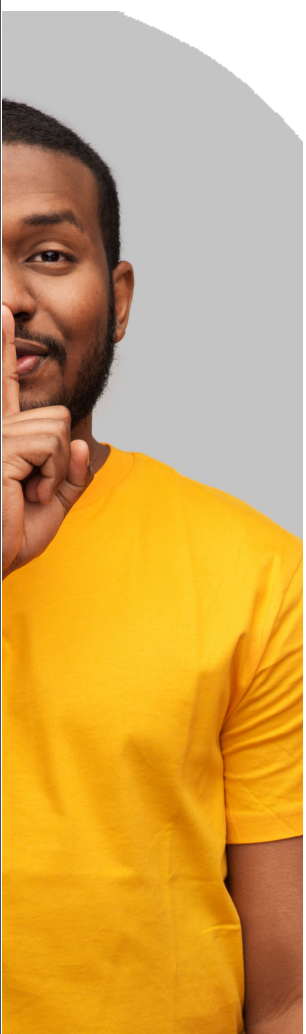


FROM EGYPT

BY PROF. DR M AMR SADIK

Co-founder and Vice President of Educators, VP Dimensions Consulting Ltd. UK

4. **DOMINANCE OF THE COLLECTIVE MIND:** Individuals in organizations refrain from participating and remain silent when they feel that their opinions are not accepted by the group. These opinions and ideas may cause them to be isolated from the group or viewed with ridicule and contempt.
5. **LACK OF TRUST IN SUPERIORS:** This is one of the reasons for resorting to silence for fear of being exposed to danger or misunderstanding information and contributions.
6. **FEAR OF SHARING:** Some call it defensive silence, which is a deliberate reluctance to share big ideas, information, and feelings as a fear-based self-protection.
7. **FEELING UNABLE TO CHANGE:** When individuals feel unable to change, and that their ideas are not taken seriously, but on the contrary, they may become part of a negative evaluation of them, then they refrain from participating and remain silent.
8. **FEAR OF HARMING BOSSES OR COWORKERS:** Employees sharing information may harm their bosses or coworkers, which may prompt them to remain silent.



IMPLICATIONS OF ORGANIZATIONAL SILENCE

FIRST: THE ORGANIZATIONAL EFFECTS OF ORGANIZATIONAL SILENCE

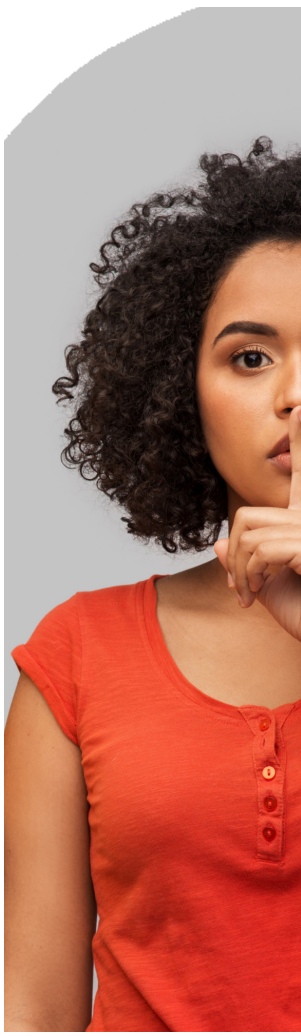
Organizational silence has significant harmful effects on the organization as a whole, and may cause high levels of dissatisfaction, represented by absence, turnover, and other undesirable behaviors. Communications are the key to success for organizations, and when organizational silence occurs, the communications system within the organization is affected, which harms the overall functions of the organization.

Organizational silence leads to killing the spirit of creativity, and the organization continues with poorly planned projects that lead to poor products and services and may lead to a decline in morale.

Organizational silence may lead to the creation of individuals who are indifferent toward their organizations, their jobs, and their work, thus causing weak levels of institutional performance for the organization as a whole, which may cause significant financial losses to the organization. Organizational silence may also cause a lack of participation in the work, in addition to not reporting any errors that are observed. It leads to a perpetual cycle of employee silence.

SECOND: THE EFFECTS OF ORGANIZATIONAL SILENCE ON EMPLOYEES

The silence of employees has many consequences and effects on the employees themselves. Indifferent employees are the product of organizational silence. Indifference leads employees to feel that they are just cogs in the factory machines, and matters may develop into a feeling of frustration or even some health problems, which prompts them to take medications or even alcoholic drinks are used to get out of this predicament, which in turn exacerbates the problem and takes it to a worse situation.



UNDERSTANDING AND ADDRESSING ORGANIZATIONAL SILENCE IS CRUCIAL FOR FOSTERING A HEALTHY, INNOVATIVE AND RESPONSIVE ORGANIZATIONAL ENVIRONMENT.

There is another example of the effects of organizational silence on employees, detailed by some researchers, who showed that organizational silence has an impact on the personal well-being of employees, increases their stress, and also makes them feel guilty, as they often face psychological problems and difficulties in seeing the possibility of change.

Most people think that organizational silence only harms the organization, but the truth of the matter is that it harms both the organization and the workers.

CONCLUSION

Today's organizations are considered knowledge-based organizations. They try to take advantage of the intellectual capital available to them in order to increase their efficiency. Therefore, it is necessary to reveal the ideas and opinions of employees and listen to the organizational voice. More precisely, the most obstacles facing organizational change are the lack of information and the lack of trust, which are the result of organizational silence, as current studies indicate, is that organizational silence is a sign of withdrawal or protest against organizational practices, and it cannot be viewed only as a type of negative acceptance of the existing situation. It goes beyond that as it constitutes a special type of message that must be revealed.

Organizational silence is a massive barrier to organizational effectiveness and employee nicely-being. by information its causes and enforcing techniques to foster open communique, groups can free up the total capability of their personnel, pressure innovation, and keep a high-quality organizational lifestyle.

Organizational silence is a behavioral choice that can deteriorate or improve organizational performance. Excluding its emotionally difficult expression, silence can convey approval and sharing or disfavor and opposition, thus becoming a pressure mechanism for both individuals and organizations. Addressing organizational silence isn't always a one-time attempt, however an ongoing determination to developing surroundings in which every voice is heard and valued.

It is a complicated trouble with deep-rooted reasons and far-accomplishing consequences. Addressing it calls for a concerted attempt from management to create an environment wherein open communique is the norm. through understanding the factors that make a contribution to silence and actively running to mitigate them, organizations can launch the total capacity of their group of workers, fostering innovation, engagement, and believe. the journey from silence to voice is essential to the lengthy-time period achievement and moral status of any business enterprise. ■

PROF. DR M AMR SADIK, is a Co-founder and Vice President of Educators, VP Dimensions Consulting Ltd. UK, based in Cairo, Egypt. He is an HBR Advisory Council Member, Adjunct HR & Strategy Management Professor at IPE Management School, Paris, Middle East Programs for, Victoria University, School of Management, Switzerland and HR Collegiate Council and HR Professor at GUST, Latvia. He was ranked by Thinkers360 as a Top 50 Thought HR Leader in 2024.